

Atoms & Nuclear Radiation.

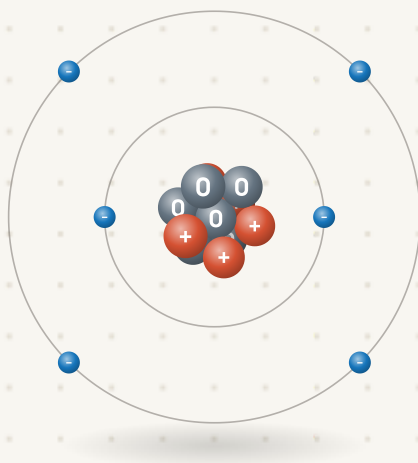
Lesson 03

From plum pudding to the nucleus

Nobody has ever seen inside an atom. So how did scientists find out that almost all of its mass is squeezed into a tiny nucleus?

IN THIS LESSON YOU WILL

- describe the plum pudding model and why it was proposed
- describe the alpha particle scattering experiment
- explain how each result led to the nuclear model
- compare the plum pudding and nuclear models



NAME

CLASS

TEACHER

TARGET GRADE

How this booklet works.

This is the booklet for **Lesson 3** of the Atoms and Nuclear Radiation unit. It builds on the lessons before it; the “Do now” questions and the quick answers at the back help you check what you remember. Keep it: it is your classwork book *and* your revision guide.



DO NOW

Quick questions from earlier lessons. Remembering again is what makes it stick.



LEARN IT

Explanations, diagrams and worked examples. Read this again when you revise.



TRY IT

Practice that builds up: first with support, then on your own, then a challenge.



LAB

Record what you find in a simulation or a model experiment.



EXAM CORNER

AQA-style questions with a tip on how the marks are given.



REVISE IT

Summary, cover-and-answer questions and an “I can” check to colour in.



Revising at home? (1) Read the Learn it pages. (2) Cover them and answer the “Cover the page” questions in Revise it. (3) Check with the quick answers at the back. (4) Go through the matching slides in the teaching deck, and try the simulations.

● The route through the unit (this lesson is highlighted)

01 Inside the atom

03 From plum pudding to the nucleus

The plum pudding model, alpha scattering and the nuclear model (slides 9–15)

05 Radioactive decay

07 Properties and uses of radiation

09 Half-life calculations

02 Isotopes and ions

04 Energy levels and the nucleus

06 Nuclear equations

08 Half-life and random decay

10 Contamination and irradiation

Teaching deck: panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation. Simulations:

panphy.app/simulations/atomic_models.html and panphy.app/simulations/nuclear_decay.html

From plum pudding to the nucleus.

AQA Physics 4.4.1.3; Combined Science 6.4.1.3

BIG QUESTION

Nobody has ever seen inside an atom. So how did scientists find out that almost all of its mass is squeezed into a tiny nucleus?

BY THE END YOU CAN

- describe the plum pudding model and why it was proposed
- describe the alpha particle scattering experiment
- explain how each result led to the nuclear model
- compare the plum pudding and nuclear models

model

plum pudding model

alpha particle

alpha scattering

deflected

nuclear model

evidence

SLIDES AND SIMULATIONS

Teaching deck, slides 9–15

Timeline of models, the plum pudding model, alpha scattering and the nuclear model.

panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation/#9

Atomic Models simulation

panphy.app/simulations/atomic_models.htm



RETRIEVE

Do now

From earlier lessons. No notes!

1

What particles are in the nucleus?

2

What is the overall charge of a nucleus? Why?

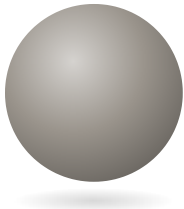
3

The radius of a nucleus is less than what fraction of the atom's radius?



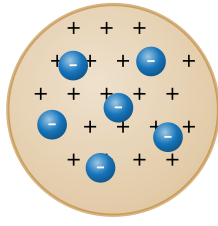
How the model changed

● A model that kept changing



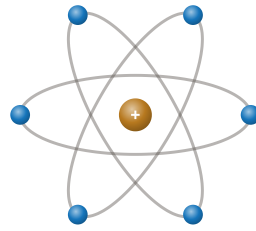
Before 1897

Tiny solid spheres that cannot be divided



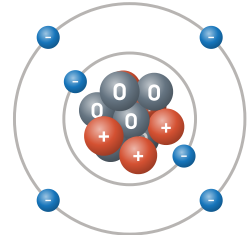
1904

Plum pudding: after the electron was discovered



1911

Nuclear model: from alpha scattering



1913

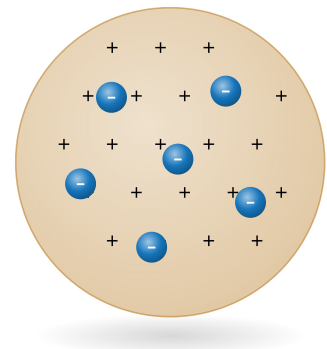
Bohr model: electrons in energy levels

Scientists use **models** to explain things too small to see. When new **evidence** does not fit a model, the model is changed or replaced.

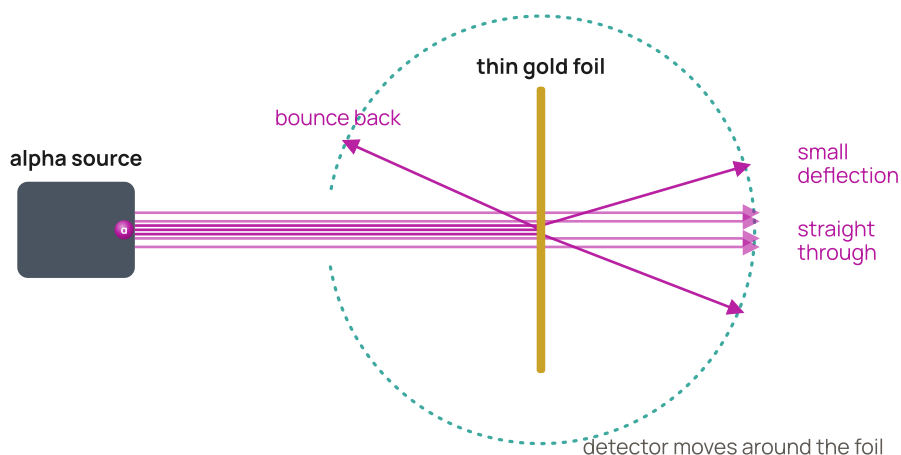
● The plum pudding model (1904)

In 1897 J. J. Thomson discovered the **electron**, a tiny negative particle that comes from inside atoms. So atoms *can* be divided into smaller parts.

This led to the **plum pudding model**: the atom is a **ball of positive charge** with **negative electrons embedded in it**. The positive charge and the mass are spread through the whole atom. There is **no nucleus**.



● The alpha scattering experiment (1909)

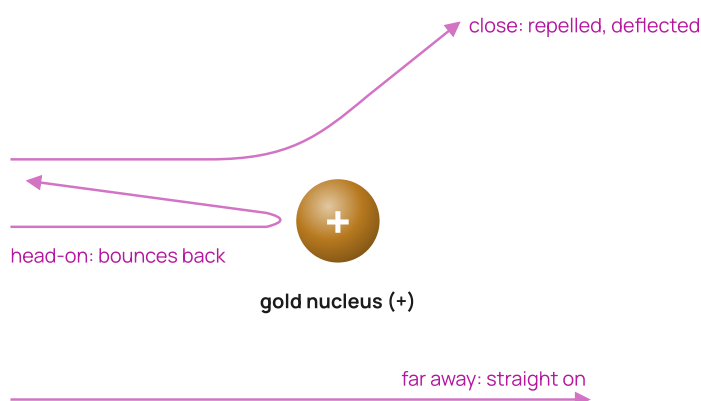


Geiger and Marsden, working with Rutherford, fired alpha particles at a very thin gold foil and counted them at every angle.

Alpha particles are small, fast and positively charged. The plum pudding model predicted that they would all pass **straight through** the foil, with at most tiny deflections, because the positive charge was spread out too thinly to push them far off course.

● What they saw, and what it means

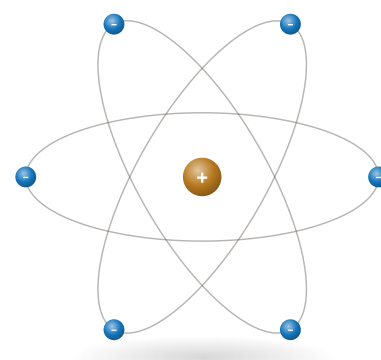
Observation	Conclusion
Most alpha particles went straight through.	The atom is mostly empty space .
Some were deflected through large angles.	The centre of the atom is positively charged : it repels the positive alpha particles.
A very few bounced back.	The mass and charge are concentrated in a tiny centre : the nucleus.



Close-up of one gold nucleus: not to scale.

● The nuclear model (Rutherford, 1911)

	Plum pudding	Nuclear model
Positive charge	spread through the atom	in a tiny nucleus
Mass	spread through the atom	concentrated in the nucleus
Empty space?	no	mostly empty space
Electrons	embedded in the positive ball	outside the nucleus



! The plum pudding model could not explain alpha particles bouncing back. The new evidence did not fit, so the model was **replaced** by the nuclear model.



Try it

- 1 Put the models of the atom in the order they were proposed. Write 1 (first) to 4 (latest) in the boxes.

A tiny, positive nucleus with electrons outside it

Tiny solid spheres that cannot be divided

Electrons orbit the nucleus at fixed distances (energy levels)

A ball of positive charge with electrons embedded in it

- 2 Draw a line from each observation to the conclusion it led to. (The answer edition shows the matching letter.)

1 Most alpha particles passed straight through.

2 Some alpha particles were deflected.

3 A very few alpha particles bounced back.

A The mass is concentrated in a tiny centre.

B Most of the atom is empty space.

C The centre of the atom has a positive charge.

- 3 Three alpha particles, A, B and C, move towards a gold nucleus. Continue the path of each one.

A  

B  

C  



gold nucleus

A passes far from the nucleus, B passes close to it and C is heading straight for it.

- 4 Explain why the plum pudding model cannot explain alpha particles bouncing back.

5 Is Mia right? Explain your answer.

Mia

Most alpha particles went straight through, so the experiment proved the plum pudding model was right.

6 **CHALLENGE** The gold foil was only a few hundred atoms thick. Suggest why a very thin foil was needed.



AQA - STYLE

Exam corner

Write in full sentences. Show every step of a calculation.

Get the marks: In a 'compare' question, say what each model says about the same feature: charge, mass, empty space, electrons.

7 Describe the differences between the plum pudding model and the nuclear model of the atom.

[4 marks]

8 In the alpha scattering experiment, most alpha particles passed straight through the gold foil, but a very small number were deflected by more than 90° . Explain what each result showed about the structure of the atom.

[4 marks]

**SUMMARY**

- Models change when new evidence does not fit them.
- Plum pudding (1904): a ball of positive charge with electrons embedded; no nucleus.
- Alpha scattering: most straight through (empty space), some deflected (positive centre), a very few bounced back (mass in a tiny centre).
- Nuclear model (1911): tiny, dense, positive nucleus with electrons outside.
- The nuclear model replaced the plum pudding model.

COVER THE PAGE AND ANSWER

1 What discovery led to the plum pudding model?

.....

3 What did bounce-backs show?

.....

2 What were alpha particles fired at?

.....

4 Where is the positive charge in the nuclear model?

.....

I CAN...

describe the plum pudding model



describe the alpha scattering experiment



link each result to a conclusion about the atom



compare the plum pudding and nuclear models



Toolkit.

The facts and methods you have met so far. Learn these: exam questions expect you to recall them without a data sheet.

The three particles

Lesson 1

Particle	Charge	Mass	Where
Proton	+1	1	nucleus
Neutron	0	1	nucleus
Electron	-1	very small	energy levels

Reading the symbol

Lesson 1

 ${}^A_Z\text{X}$ e.g. ${}^{23}_{11}\text{Na}$

- Z, atomic number = protons
- A, mass number = protons + neutrons
- neutrons = A - Z; in an atom, electrons = Z
- Atom radius $\approx 1 \times 10^{-10}$ m; nucleus radius $< 1/10\,000$ of that

Isotopes and ions

Lesson 2

- **Isotopes:** same number of protons, different numbers of neutrons.
- **Positive ion:** an atom that has lost one or more outer electrons. The nucleus is unchanged.

Alpha scattering

Lesson 3

Observation	Conclusion
most straight through	mostly empty space
some deflected	positive centre
a very few bounced back	mass in a tiny centre

Key words from this lesson.

Learn the meaning and spelling. In exams, precise words earn marks: say “nucleus”, not “middle”, and “unstable nucleus”, not “unstable atom”.

Alpha scattering: The experiment in which alpha particles fired at thin gold foil showed that atoms have a tiny, positive nucleus.

Evidence: Observations and measurements used to test a model.

Model: A simplified explanation of something we cannot see directly; changed when new evidence does not fit.

Nuclear model: A tiny, dense, positive nucleus with electrons outside it (Rutherford, 1911).

Plum pudding model: A ball of positive charge with negative electrons embedded in it (1904).

CHECK YOURSELF

Quick answers.

Answers to the “Do now” and “Cover the page” questions, so you can check yourself when revising. Answers to the longer questions are in the answer edition.

DO NOW

1. Protons and neutrons.
2. Positive: protons are positive and neutrons have no charge.
3. $1/10\,000$

COVER THE PAGE

1. The electron (atoms can be divided).
2. Very thin gold foil.
3. The mass (and positive charge) is concentrated in a tiny centre, the nucleus.
4. In a tiny nucleus at the centre.